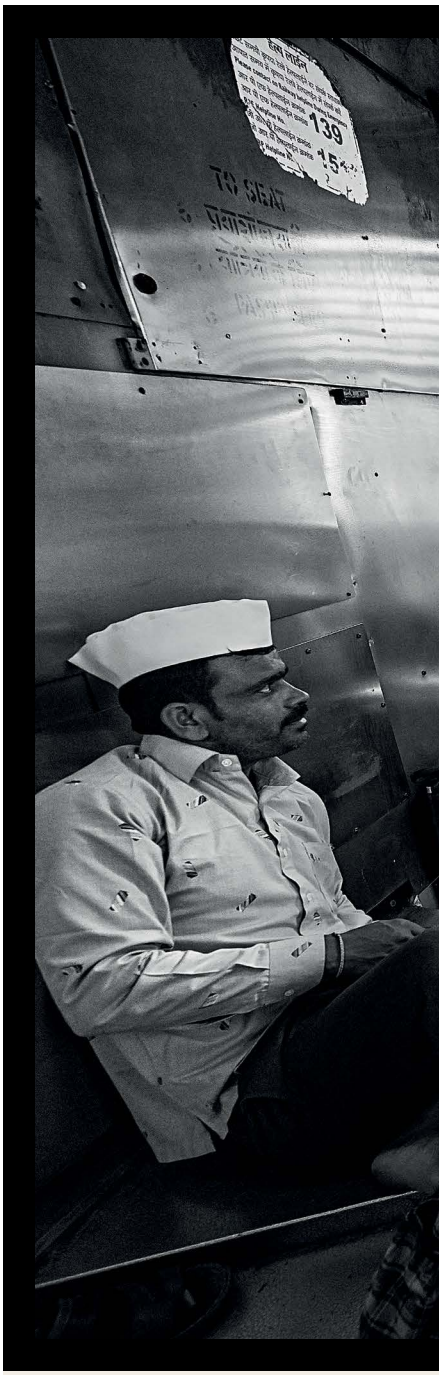
IF a city was a novel, this could be it: a piece of magic realism coming out of a lunch box. Think of it as a simple narrative device that holds within itself the Mumbai story. The biography of faceless millions who make up its brick and mortar, its moving human architecture, and innate genius. With a humble task and a name like 'the dabbawalas', a decidedly dowdy one that refuses any stylistic gloss, you would imagine the associated cast of characters to be lost in the heaving blur of humanity that made up the unchic suburbs, fading out to the vast and rough-hewn ruralia beyond. Sweat, grime, toil...and suburban trains packed like sardines. But then, you see them rub shoulders with the beau monde at Windsor Guildhall, when Prince Charles married Camilla Parker-Bowles. You see the swashbuckling knight of aviation, Sir Richard Branson, moving in their midst on terra firma. Not breaking bread, but delivering bread—in unfashionable aluminium and steel dabbas. But is that chapter of the novel coming to a close? Is lunch time over?

Look at the years. It was 2003 when Prince Charles came to India and met the dabbawalas. The royal wedding, where the representative duo of Raghunath Medge and Sopan Mare went as guests, was two years later. The Branson brouhaha was also in 2005. Yes, that fond connection with a fawning world was renewed this year. When Charles finally became Charles III at the ripe old age of 75, a traditional Puneri pagadi (headgear) and uparne (stole) were part of the gifts at the coronation. It was an unusual friendship: an individual with eminence thrust upon him by heredity, and a collective from the boondocks that earned its iconicity. That too with teamwork of such pinpoint balletic precision as to be very rare in India's individualistic culture. But, like the new King of England, the dabbawalas too appear like surviving relics from another age. The world has changed, and much water has muddied the Mahim Creek in between. To take just one event that catalysed change, before the coronation, there was corona....

Janardhan Gavande has no time to wonder whether he's part of something iconic, or one of a vanishing species. He has a train to catch. Every morning, he starts from his home in Ghatkopar, once a village that got devoured by the city but still carries the old country smell in its name. Destination: Dadar. Trawling this central Mumbai neighbourhood on his cycle, he picks up tiffin boxes from his regulars—on an average, about three dozen. This gets pedalled back to the railway station. Here, the whole incoming stream of dabbas is sorted based on their delivery destinations. Mumbai's rail network has some 240 such "touch points", each serviced by a group of dabbawalas, a tiny squad of four-five men or a platoon of 15-20, even 50, supervised by a *mukadam* (overseer). Gavande takes his lot to Churchgate, the art-deco heart of south Mumbai. Here, like a diligent worker ant, he hand-delivers the individual consignments. His clients? Sundry employees at their desks inside the cubbyhole offices of the state govern-



INSTITUTION UNTO THEMSELVES

Those magnificent men in their trademark Gandhi caps have delivered home food to millions, forming an organic link between the city and its Marathi hinterland